right.

Even now, when he received news of the rebels' proclamation, Akbar acted in no haste. For all the unrest among sections of his nobility, for all the unhappiness of his critics, Akbar's talent for conquest and organization had given him a vast and largely stable realm. He was thirty-eight years old and had ruled a quarter-century; no longer the young monarch who galloped after Adham Khan, after Ali Quli and Bahadur, after the Mirzas, a furious whirlwind establishing his authority by sweeping away any affront to it. Now, he could have other men do the job for him.

Three weeks after the mutineers' assembly, on 9 June 1580, Akbar met Aziz. His milk brother had been in the doghouse for half a decade, ever since he damned Akbar's reforms in 1575, but there were few men that Akbar could trust more than him. A 'river of milk' bound them, as the emperor would say,[27] excusing Aziz's sharp tongue and the fact that he never quite learnt to speak to his old friend as he ought to an emperor. Now, Aziz was restored to great favour: titled Khan Azam – the greatest khan – given command of an imperial army and the highest mansabdari rank, 5000 – and sent to quell the east.

Aziz was not the only man whom Akbar could rely on. His Persian courtiers remained broadly loyal to the emperor.[28] Even more so, the Hindustanis (not only Rajputs, but also Todar Mal and Indian Muslims such as the quarrelsome Punjabi Shahbaz Khan, for example), whom Akbar had cultivated over the years, had little sympathy with his disenchanted, disenfranchised Central Asian chiefs, and 'as a body sided with the King'.[29]

Aziz was one of three senior commanders, therefore, that Akbar sent east; the other two were Todar Mal and Shahbaz Khan. All were true to their emperor; but all were also men of great pride, with little love lost for each other. As the campaign progressed, the imperial commanders were as much at loggerheads with each other as with the rebels. As Abul Fazl puts it, Shahbaz Khan 'looked at himself in the mirror, liked what he saw, and fell prey to arrogance'; Aziz was 'disgusted' at such preening self-importance; while Todar Mal 'threw in the towel'.[30]

Luckily, the rebels were similarly divided. It was one of Sharafuddin's new-found allies, for example, who finally ended his mutinous career. According to Abul Fazl, Sharafuddin acquired a dangerous rival in Masum